

Zarathushtra (Zoroaster, Zaratus, etc.) often figures as an Assyrian or a Babylonian. This means that Greek scholars travelling in the East found the Zarathushtrian religion predominant in the Babylonian plain. In Jewish-Christian tradition the legendary ruler of Babylon, Nimrod, was identified with Zoroaster. Iranian religion pushed yet further westwards during the period with which we are concerned, in the form of Mithraism, which was very closely related and sprang from the same roots. Antiochus of Commagene, in the first half of the first century B.C., was a Mithraist, as we learn with certainty from his famous epitaph. The religion of the pirates conquered by Pompey, who came mostly from Cilicia and Cyprus, must also have been Mithraism. Contacts between Judaism and Iranian religion were abundant during the last centuries B.C. It may further be noted that the relations of Judaism to the Persian empire were from the first very friendly. To the Persians Judaism largely owed its restoration. And in the following centuries it appears to have remained altogether unmolested within that empire, and with complete freedom of development.

---

again in III. 39. 10, Darius sets out for Issus with Magi who come second after the sacred fire, followed by 365 youths "puniceis amiculis velati, diebus totius anni pares numero." My colleague Prof. Tait notes for me the limitations of Curtius, who depended too much on the rhetorical writers of the century after Alexander: unless supported by Arrian, who had narratives written by Alexander's generals, his facts are usually viewed with some distrust. Here one may say there is nothing improbable, though we cannot prove that the description represents conditions older than the age of the historian. I may observe that the detail about the 365 youths is simply Mithraic: cf. Jerome, *In Amos*, v. 9-10 (ap. Cumont, *Textes*, ii. 19), where it is said that Basilides made 'Αβράξας supreme god, meaning thereby the course of the year, "quem ethnici sub eodem nomine aliarum litterarum vocant Μείθρας." (Μείθρας and 'Αβράξας alike have letters whose numerical value totals 365.) Prof. Jackson holds that Curtius has "much that is truly Persian," and would not rule out the 365 youths as standing for the solar year.